

Core Criteria Checklist

Use this checklist to quickly determine if your property is ready to complete the Core Criteria and proceed toward Eco-Rating Certification.

The Core Criteria represent 37 foundational sustainability practices required to achieve a 1-Key Eco-Rating Certification. Many hotels already have these practices in place as part of standard operations. If your property can confidently check most of the items below, you are likely well-positioned to complete the Core Criteria and move toward certification audit (hotels must submit all necessary documentation required for the completed questions).

1. Sustainability Governance

Your property should have basic management practices that support sustainability across hotel operations.

- ☐ A written sustainability or environmental policy exists for the property
- ☐ Sustainability responsibilities are assigned to a designated staff member or Green Team
- ☐ Sustainability practices are communicated to staff
- ☐ Sustainability considerations are included in operational decision-making

Helpful Tip:

Many hotels already have policies that can satisfy this requirement. Hotels can use/modify their brand's policy as well. If not, a simple written environmental commitment statement can often fulfill the criteria

2. Energy Management

Hotels should demonstrate basic practices for monitoring and improving energy performance.

- ☐ The property tracks energy consumption (electricity, gas, etc.)
- ☐ Energy-efficient lighting is installed in guest rooms or public areas
- ☐ Energy efficiency practices are used in equipment and operations
- ☐ Staff are encouraged to support energy conservation practices

Helpful Tip:

Utility bills and existing energy management systems can often satisfy tracking requirements.

3. Water Conservation

Hotels should demonstrate responsible water management practices.

- ☐ Water consumption is monitored or tracked
- ☐ Water-efficient fixtures are installed where feasible
- ☐ Guests are encouraged to participate in water conservation programs (e.g., linen or towel reuse)
- ☐ Staff are trained to identify and report leaks or inefficiencies

Helpful Tip:

Existing towel and linen reuse programs typically contribute toward this requirement.

4. Waste Reduction

Hotels should demonstrate responsible waste management and reduction practices.

- ☐ The property has recycling procedures in place
- ☐ Waste reduction practices are implemented in guest areas or operations

- ☐ Waste is separated where possible
- ☐ Staff are informed about proper waste management procedures

Helpful Tip:

Existing recycling programs already implemented by many hotels often satisfy several criteria in this section

5. Staff Engagement

Employees play a critical role in successful sustainability programs.

- ☐ Staff receive basic training or guidance on sustainability practices
- ☐ Sustainability responsibilities are integrated into operational roles
- ☐ Staff are encouraged to identify sustainability improvements

Helpful Tip:

This training can be integrated into existing staff onboarding or operational briefings.

6. Operational Sustainability Practices

Hotels should demonstrate basic operational practices that support responsible resource management.

- ☐ Sustainability considerations are incorporated into purchasing decisions where possible
- ☐ Operational procedures help reduce unnecessary resource use (e.g., having a comprehensive maintenance program in place)
- ☐ Environmental practices are communicated internally or to guests

Helpful Tip:

Many operational practices already implemented to reduce costs also support sustainability objectives.

Signs Your Property Is Ready for Certification

Your property is likely ready to complete the Core Criteria if:

- ✓ Sustainability policies or environmental commitments already exist
- ✓ Basic energy and water monitoring practices are in place
- ✓ Recycling or waste reduction programs are operational
- ✓ Staff participate in sustainability practices

Many hotels discover they already meet a significant portion of the Core Criteria.

What Happens Next?

Once your property completes the 37 baseline requirements of Core Criteria (along with uploading of necessary documentation) within the Eco-Rating assessment, you are eligible to proceed to an audit. After a successful audit, your property will receive a 1-Key Eco-Rating Certification, recognizing your commitment to sustainable hotel operations. Hotels may also continue the full Eco-Rating assessment to pursue higher certification ratings.

Need Help?

We have added additional guides and templates to help members answer the 37 Core Criteria questions. Green Key Global's [Member Services team](#) is available to assist with questions about completing the Core Criteria or preparing for certification.

Take the Next Step

[Log into the Eco-Rating assessment](#) platform to review the Core Criteria and start or continue your progress toward certification.